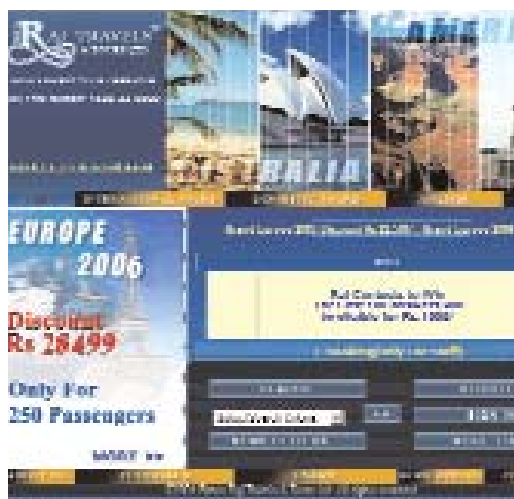




Raj Travels' homepage

Read The Fine Print

And that's why you simply must read the fine print. Mind you, this still does not include airport taxes (if any) at Singapore, cost of visa, and any other 'overheads'. Simply put, this trip could cost anywhere between Rs 50,000 and Rs 60,000 (including some shopping and other necessary expenses). \$49 was only a marketing price.

Anyway, these sites also offer online flight booking, adventure holiday package booking, honeymoon packages, wildlife holidays and even car bookings.

Travel portals apart, leading travel agencies are also offering online booking options today. Raj Travels (<http://rajtravels.com>) is one of the few travel agencies that allows you to book online

using ICICI Bank's payment gateway.

Some of the other bigger agencies such as Cox and Kings, SOTC and Kesari Tours, to name a few, have a lot of information on their sites, but do not offer the option of booking your trip online.

SOTC, for example, allows you to download a PDF of their booking form and print it out yourself. Cox and Kings allows you to 'Plan Your Trip',

but this is really not as interactive or 'online' as one would have liked—all you can do is enter some basic info and wait for them to write back to you with details. The same is the case with Kesari Tours, who let you 'Book Now'—but at the fag end of the process it's revealed that a "sales person would get in touch with you shortly". Bummer!

Planning your own trip is also possible via an airline portal such as Jet Airways' or that of Sahara Airlines or even Indian Airlines. Jet also offers 'Jet Getaways', a travel package in addition to their ticket booking option. Similarly, Sahara Airlines has its own travel packages going to domestic locations like Goa and Kerala and some international destinations

I- and E-Ticketing: IRCTC

I-Tickets can be delivered to the customer at his desired address through courier. This delivery of I-Tickets through courier is limited to postal addresses covered by the PIN codes listed under the 'Places of Delivery' link.

For E-Tickets (e-reservations), the user can take a printout of the Reservation Slip and conduct the journey without requiring the regular ticket to be delivered.



We missed the IRCTC online booking by just about 2 minutes!

Reproduced from www.irctc.com

like Singapore. Of course, the air travel has to happen with them!

If, however, you want to plan your own trip, you can fix your flight plan online, book and even print your tickets at home. You use these tickets to enter the airport and you're issued boarding passes against them.

Airlines today are highly competitive, and this augurs well for the traveller. Special offers, frequent flyer miles and even tickets up for bidding means there's always a better price available. Once again, be sure to read the fine print very carefully. Spice Jet, one of the new entrants in the domestic airspace, is also letting you to choose your seats at the time of booking.

Railway booking online, too, has been a reality for some time now. The Indian Railways Catering and Tourism Corporation (<http://irctc.co.in>) requires a sign-up and then you're away. Some special schemes even allow your payments to be broken into EMIs.

The IRCTC has gone a step further and is also allowing SMS booking. You need to provide them with the cell number at the time of sign-up, and as of right now, payment is possible only through ICICI Bank.

But here's the baffling part: reservation is possible only between 4 AM and 11.30 PM. As is evident in the screenshot above, we missed it... by two minutes!

Despite all the shortcomings and quirks though, online travel planning is a reality. You no longer need to suffer long queues before you can relax!

Links

Airline	Type of Airline	Online Booking	Web site
Air India	Domestic and International	Yes	www.airindia.com
Indian Airlines	Domestic and International	Yes	www.indian-airlines.nic.in
Air Sahara	Domestic and International	Yes	www.airsahara.net
Jet Airways	Domestic and International	Yes	www.jetairways.com
Spice Jet	Domestic	Yes	www.spicejet.com
Air Charters India	Domestic (Charter flights)	No	www.airchartersindia.net
Air India Express	Domestic and International	Yes	www.airindiaexpress.in
Deccan Air	Domestic	Yes	www.airdeccan.net
Kingfisher Airlines	Domestic	Yes	www.flyingfisher.com
Travel Agency	Offers	Online Booking	Web site
Cox and Kings	Domestic and outbound tours; special packages	No; only info collected	www.coxandkings.com
SOTC	Outbound tours	No; only info collected	www.sotc.co.in
Kesari Tours	Domestic and outbound tours; special packages	No; only info collected	www.kesari.in
Raj Travels	Domestic and outbound tours; special packages	Yes	www.rajtravels.com
MakeMyTrip.com	All types of tours including adventure holidays	Yes	www.makemytrip.com
TravelJini.com	All types of tours including adventure holidays	No; only info collected	www.traveljini.com